

Project Plan: High Street GenAI Learning Hub

Introduction and Vision

In many communities, there is a need for a “*third space*” – a place outside of home and work where people can gather, learn, and collaborate in a non-commercial, inclusive environment. As author Zadie Smith put it, “*Libraries are the only thing left on the high street that doesn’t want either your soul or your wallet.*” ¹ This project seeks to revive that spirit by creating a modern community hub on the town high street dedicated to Generative AI (GenAI) learning and experimentation. The vision is a welcoming, café-like **GenAI Learning Hub** that demystifies AI technology and empowers citizens to use these tools positively in their daily lives. This space will serve as a “**third place**” (after home and work/school) for creativity and education, much as public libraries have historically anchored high streets as community learning centers ².

Goals and Objectives: The Hub’s core mission is to make GenAI accessible to all, ensuring no one is left behind by the AI revolution. Key objectives include:

- **Demystify and Educate:** Provide hands-on introductions to generative AI (text, image, coding, etc.) in a friendly setting, reducing fear and misunderstanding about AI.
- **Empower Productivity:** Show how tools like GPT-based assistants and AI art generators can massively boost personal and team productivity, drawing on the project lead’s own experience of “massive empowerment” using AI for work and creativity.
- **Community and Inclusion:** Re-establish a non-political, non-commercial community space where **all ages** and backgrounds can learn side by side – from students and tech enthusiasts to seniors and local business owners. The hub will *bridge generations* and skill levels in a positive, collaborative atmosphere.
- **Promote Open Technology:** Emphasize open-source AI solutions and Creative Commons content, fostering a spirit of transparency and shared learning. All educational materials and code examples produced will be open-source and CC-licensed, aligning with a broader movement towards openness in AI development ³.
- **Sustainable Growth:** Start small and iterate rapidly on what works. Develop a viable community-driven business model so the concept can sustain itself and eventually scale to many towns and cities. (This *lean startup* approach will be detailed below, focusing on quick iteration, finding revenue streams, and scaling out once proven.)

By achieving these goals, the High Street GenAI Hub will become a prototype for how towns across the country (and even across Europe) can engage their citizens with transformative technologies in an accessible, “*safe space*” setting.

Target Audience and Community Impact

This initiative targets a **broad audience** – essentially *anyone curious about generative AI*. Key groups include:

- **Wider Tech Audience:** *Tech enthusiasts, students, and professionals* who want to explore AI’s latest models and applications. They might already have some tech background but lack a local

community to share and deepen their knowledge. The hub offers them a physical space to meet like-minded peers and collaborate.

- **Social Entrepreneurs & Innovators:** Individuals looking to apply GenAI to solve community or business problems. The hub provides mentorship, brainstorming space, and even potential teammates for launching new ideas with AI at the core. By fostering these connections, the hub could spark local startups or social enterprises.
- **General Public & Underserved Groups:** Crucially, the space is also for *absolute beginners*, including those who may feel intimidated by new tech. This includes **older adults, career changers, or people from non-tech sectors** who have heard of AI but don't know how to start. For example, Singapore's government recognized the importance of upskilling older workers by subsidizing AI education for citizens aged 40+ ⁴ – a recognition that everyone, not just the young, should have the chance to thrive in an AI-driven economy. Inspired by such initiatives, our hub will run gentle introductory sessions (e.g. “*GenAI Basics for Seniors*” or “*AI for the Curious Beginner*”) to ensure *no one is left behind*. As noted in a recent analysis, supporting middle-aged and older workers in acquiring new digital skills is vital to adapting to our rapidly changing world ⁵.
- **Youth and Educators:** While not exclusively a kids' program, the hub will welcome students (with appropriate supervision or parental consent for younger ones) and teachers. It can complement school curricula by offering creative coding workshops, AI art projects, or after-school **Code Club** style sessions. (Code Club is a successful model of free coding clubs using kid-friendly tools like Scratch and Raspberry Pi ⁶, demonstrating that informal, mentor-led learning can greatly inspire young people.) The GenAI Hub can build on this model – for instance, running a “*Young Creators Lab*” where teenagers use generative AI to write stories or create music, guided by volunteers.

Community Benefits: By engaging this wide audience, the hub aims for significant social impact: increased digital literacy, stronger intergenerational bonds, and a more innovation-friendly local culture. Neighbors will transform into learners and mentors for each other. Small business owners might learn to use AI tools for marketing or productivity, job-seekers can gain new skills, and students can find career inspiration. Overall, the town stands to benefit from a more tech-savvy populace and the **sense of community** that arises when people gather to learn for mutual benefit. This echoes what libraries and makerspaces have achieved – for example, public libraries are often called unique third spaces that anchor communities and encourage lifelong learning ². Our GenAI Hub updates that concept for the 21st century, focusing on AI as the “glue” that brings diverse groups together in a shared learning journey.

Hub Features and Resources

The **GenAI Learning Hub** will be a physical space on the high street designed for both casual drop-in use and structured learning. Key features and resources include:

- **Café-Style Coziness:** A welcoming café-like atmosphere with comfortable seating and Wi-Fi, where people can grab a tea or coffee and explore AI at their own pace. The idea is to emulate the relaxed vibe of a coffee shop **combined** with the learning resources of a library or tech lab. *Having a small coffee/snack bar on-site not only draws people in but can also serve as a modest revenue stream to support the hub.* Importantly, like Zadie Smith's description of libraries, this will be a commercial-free zone in terms of usage – buying a coffee is optional, and the core learning activities are free or at a token cost.
- **Computers & Equipment:** A set of **workstations** (desktops or laptops) with necessary software and internet access will be available for public use. Users can also bring their own devices and

connect to the hub's network. Each workstation will be pre-loaded with a suite of GenAI tools and examples, especially *open-source* models. For example:

- **Generative AI Software:** Access to text-generation models (like local instances of GPT-style LLMs, e.g. an open-source LLaMA or GPT-J model), image generators (e.g. Stable Diffusion which is a well-known open-source image model ³), and other creative AI tools (music generation, coding assistants, etc.). Whenever possible, *open-source AI models* will be used to ensure cost-effectiveness and independence; these models allow anyone to run and improve them without proprietary restrictions ³. (We will also have guidance on using popular cloud AI services responsibly, but the emphasis is on transparency and hands-on tinkering with AI, not just consuming a polished commercial product.)
- **Educational Content:** A digital library of tutorials, example projects, and “try it yourself” exercises will be maintained on each machine or via an intranet site. For instance, interactive tutorials on prompt writing, or Jupyter notebooks demonstrating how to fine-tune a small AI model, etc. All content will be Creative Commons licensed so it can be freely copied, remixed, and even shared with those who cannot attend in person.
- **Maker and Hardware Kits:** In the spirit of coding clubs and makerspaces, the hub will also have some **hardware kits** – like Raspberry Pi microcomputers, Arduino boards, sensors, and simple robotics kits. This enables projects that combine AI with physical computing (for example, a Raspberry Pi running a local chatbot that talks to people, or an Arduino robot that uses an AI vision model to navigate). Such resources channel the “*maker studio*” energy – similar to existing makerspaces – into GenAI projects. We envision a corner of the space functioning like a mini-makerspace, where people can tinker and build things. The success of many community makerspaces shows the value of this hands-on approach; for example, the ARTEC makerspace in Pottstown, PA operates on that town’s High Street and runs maker workshops for all ages ⁷, even integrating with a local café to create an inviting, creative environment ⁸. Our hub can emulate these best practices by providing tools and a friendly setting for “*learning by doing*.”
- **Demonstration Zones:** To spark interest, the hub could have a few **demo stations** or interactive exhibits. Imagine a setup where a screen continuously showcases AI-generated art or a text terminal where anyone can walk up and converse with a locally running chatbot assistant. These mini-exhibits serve a dual purpose: attracting foot traffic from passersby (e.g., a colorful AI art display visible from the storefront) and giving newcomers a zero-pressure way to see GenAI in action.
- **Learning Space:** In addition to the casual seating, the layout will include a more structured area for workshops and classes – perhaps a small classroom or conference room setup with a projector. This area can host scheduled training sessions, guest lectures, or community meetups in a quieter environment separated from the café bustle. When not in use for formal events, it remains open for any groups who need a table to collaborate on a project.
- **Support and Mentorship:** A hallmark of the hub will be the presence of **volunteers or staff “AI Mentors.”** Much like librarians in a library or mentors in a Code Club, these individuals will be available to answer questions and guide users. For example, a visitor might come in with a question like “How can AI help me in my small bakery business?” and a mentor could sit with them to explore solutions (perhaps showing how to use ChatGPT to generate a flyer or a new recipe). We anticipate recruiting tech-savvy volunteers (local developers, university students, or retired IT professionals) who are passionate about GenAI and community service. Their role is critical in making newcomers feel welcome and supported as they experiment.

- **Resource Hub (Physical and Online):** The space will maintain bulletin boards and an online forum for sharing **opportunities and success stories**. This might include job postings in AI, upcoming tech events in town, or profiles of local people who created something cool with generative AI. Celebrating *local success stories* can inspire others – for instance, if a group of residents who met at the hub end up starting a successful AI-driven project, their journey can be showcased to motivate more participation. An online extension (website or Discord/Slack community) will ensure the hub’s knowledge-sharing isn’t limited to the physical space and hours.

In summary, the hub will combine the **accessibility of a public library, the creativity of a makerspace, and the comfort of a café** – all focused on hands-on engagement with generative AI. The careful mix of infrastructure (computers, devices, internet), content (tutorials, examples), and human support (mentors, community) will create a safe sandbox for learning. People should walk in curious and walk out excited by what they just tried or learned, whether it’s a retiree who just wrote her first AI-assisted poem or a teenager who trained a tiny AI model on their own data.

Programs and Activities

To fulfill its mission, the GenAI Learning Hub will host a rich calendar of programs catering to different skill levels and interests. We will start with a **small set of core programs** and expand as we learn what the community responds to. All activities will emphasize *“learning by doing”* in a supportive group setting. Key programs include:

- **Introductory Workshops:** Regular **beginner-friendly workshops** to introduce the fundamentals of generative AI. These might be titled *“Getting Started with AI for Everyone”* or *“Demystifying GenAI.”* In a 2-hour session, participants could get a tour of what GenAI can do: see ChatGPT answer questions, watch Stable Diffusion create art from prompts, and even try a simple hands-on exercise (like each person comes up with a prompt and generates an image or paragraph to share with the group). These intro sessions would run frequently (e.g. every week or two), ensuring a constant onboarding path for newcomers. Special editions can target specific groups – e.g. *“GenAI for Seniors”* with a slower pace and analogies to past technologies for context, or *“GenAI for Parents and Kids”* as a family workshop.
- **Themed Short-Courses:** For those wanting a bit more depth, the hub will offer short-course series (perhaps 3-4 weekly sessions) on particular topics. Examples:
 - *“AI for Small Business”* – teaching local entrepreneurs how to use generative AI for marketing, customer service (like creating a FAQ chatbot), or business planning.
 - *“Creative Arts and AI”* – exploring how artists, writers, or musicians can co-create with AI tools. Participants might experiment with AI image generation to create art prints or use AI to help write a short story or song.
 - *“Coding with AI Assistance”* – a course where budding programmers learn how to use AI coding assistants (like GitHub Copilot) and also get an intro to building simple AI models. This could attract young adults or professionals looking to enhance their coding workflow with AI.
 - *“Open-Source AI Toolkit”* – a hands-on series focused on installing and using open models (covering things like setting up Stable Diffusion on a PC, fine-tuning a smaller language model on custom data, etc.). This caters to the more tech-savvy crowd and reinforces the open-tech philosophy.

- ● **Ongoing Code/Build Club:** Drawing inspiration from Code Club and makerspace “open lab” hours, we will have at least one weekly **drop-in lab session**. Think of it as “*GenAI Club*” where people can work on personal projects with mentors around to help. No formal agenda – one person might be trying to build a chatbot, another is playing with AI to design game characters, someone else is just asking questions that came up during their home use of ChatGPT. This unstructured time is important for community building. It lets beginners learn from more experienced peers in a natural way, and it gives experienced users a chance to solidify their knowledge by helping others (a known win-win in learning communities). The environment will be friendly and *no question is too basic*. Over time, we hope a **peer-to-peer support network** flourishes, lessening reliance on formal instructors.
- ● **Guest Talks and Meetups:** The hub will leverage local and global networks to host **guest speakers or themed meetups** at least monthly. For example, inviting an industry expert to give a talk on AI ethics, or a local artist to show their AI-augmented artwork, or organizing a panel of local business owners to discuss how they’ve adopted AI in their work. These events raise awareness and can draw in people who might not attend a class but are curious about the topic being discussed. We could also collaborate with existing tech meetups (for instance, if there’s a Python user group or an entrepreneurship club in town, they could use the space for a GenAI-themed meetup).
- ● **Youth Programs:** Partnering with schools or youth organizations, the hub can designate some after-school hours for **kids and teens**. A weekly “*Young Innovators*” session might involve activities like programming a chatbot using Scratch (there are Scratch extensions for AI, or simple ways to call AI APIs), building a simple AI-powered game, or brainstorming the ethics of AI in a moderated discussion. The aim is to ignite curiosity in younger minds in a fun, low-pressure way. We’ll ensure these activities are project-based (so the kids *make something* each time, which they can proudly show off). Ties with programs like Raspberry Pi Foundation’s projects could be beneficial – e.g., using their step-by-step project guides for inspiration ⁹.
- ● **Cross-Generational Learning Events:** A unique feature of our programming will be events that explicitly bring different age groups together. For instance, a “*Tech Buddies*” day where we invite seniors and teenagers to pair up – the teens can help the seniors with using AI tools on smartphones or computers (digital literacy), and seniors can share domain knowledge or life experience that the youth might then try to encode into a small “expert system” AI. Such exchanges build community empathy and break down stereotypes (younger people learn patience and communication; older people gain confidence and combat isolation). Another idea is an **AI Pet Project Day** where parents or grandparents come with kids to jointly create something (like a family photo album story written by AI, or a physical craft augmented with AI-generated designs). These events reinforce that the Hub is truly for *everyone*.
- ● **Hackathons and Challenges:** Once the community base is strong, we can host occasional **hackathons or innovation challenges**. For example, a weekend hackathon to “Build an AI that benefits our town” might yield cool projects like a chatbot that answers questions about local history, or an AI that generates personalized walking tours. These events can be done in collaboration with sponsors (e.g., a tech company or the city council might sponsor prizes). Even a small-scale 8-hour hack day can energize participants and produce prototypes that live on. It’s also great publicity for the hub – showcasing tangible outputs to the broader community.
- ● **Outreach and Pop-ups:** To reach those who may not initially come into the space, the project can do outreach: for instance, setting up a “*GenAI Corner*” at the public library on weekends, or

running a demonstration booth at the town market/fair. These pop-up events funnel new people into the main hub by piquing their interest. We will coordinate with existing community centers and libraries rather than compete – for example, libraries could host some of our beginner workshops in their branches, leveraging their audience and our content. The goal is a **hub-and-spoke model** of learning, with the high street location as the central resource hub, and other community venues as satellite touchpoints.

All programs will be continuously refined based on feedback. We will track attendance, collect participant feedback forms, and observe which activities generate the most engagement or requests for follow-up. Starting with a modest menu of offerings and then growing organically ensures we allocate effort to what truly serves the community's needs. Success will look like vibrant sessions where seats are filled, people are actively collaborating, and perhaps even *volunteering* to lead their own sessions as they gain confidence.

Implementation Plan and Milestones

To turn this vision into reality, the project will follow a phased implementation with rapid iteration. The mantra is **“start small, learn fast, and scale out.”** Below is a high-level roadmap:

Phase 1: Foundation (Months 0–3) – *Planning and Partnerships*

- **Core Team & Entity Formation:** Assemble a small founding team (project lead, a few volunteers/advisors with relevant skills in AI, education, and community organizing). Establish the project as a legal entity, ideally a **Community Interest Company (CIC)** in the UK. A CIC is a special form of social enterprise designed for businesses that trade for community benefit ¹⁰. This structure ensures our “third space” remains mission-locked to community good, combining the flexibility of a company with a legal *asset lock* so that profits (if any) are reinvested into the community purpose ¹¹. We will register the CIC and set up governance (a board including community representatives and possibly advisors from education or tech sectors).

- **Initial Partnerships:** Reach out to key stakeholders – e.g., the local council, public library network, nearby universities or colleges, and tech companies with local presence. The aim is to secure support such as a *venue*, seed funding or in-kind donations, and publicity. For instance, the council might have an unused retail space on the high street that could be offered at low rent, or a local college might provide surplus computer equipment. Emphasize the shared goal of digital inclusion and innovation to align with their agendas. Also, approach organizations like the Raspberry Pi Foundation or local maker communities for guidance and potential collaboration (as our concept overlaps with digital making and education). We can cite examples like the **Pottstown Social Innovations Lab**, which partnered with a local school and even houses a café, demonstrating a community-backed model on a high street ⁸. Such case studies can help convince stakeholders of the viability and impact.

- **Needs Assessment:** Conduct a quick community survey (online and via local events) to gauge interest and specific needs. Ask questions like: “What would you want to learn or do with AI?”, “What barriers keep you from exploring new tech?”, “Preferred times and formats for workshops?” This data will inform scheduling and program design to fit local demand.

- **Pilot Space Setup:** Secure a small pilot location. If an independent storefront isn’t immediately available, consider starting within an existing space (for example, renting a room in the library or community center a few days a week, or sharing space with a friendly café or coworking space). This **pop-up pilot hub** will allow us to test the concept with minimal overhead. Set up a few computers and a basic coffee station there. Ensure the environment is **inviting and branded** – some posters, clear signage that walk-ins are welcome, etc.

- **Program Beta-Launch:** Offer a handful of pilot events to kick off – e.g., one intro workshop and one drop-in evening – even before the space is fully furnished. Starting programming early (perhaps at

partner venues) helps build a user base and momentum while renovations or setup continue. We'll advertise these initial events through social media, community boards, and partner mailing lists.

Milestone: By end of Phase 1, we aim to have the legal entity established, at least one partnership secured (for space or funding), and a modest pilot location ready to host visitors. Success is measured by getting the **first visitors through the door** and gathering their feedback.

Phase 2: Pilot Operation (Months 4–6) – Launch, Learn, and Iterate

- **Grand Opening of Pilot Hub:** Host an opening event at the space, inviting press, partners, and the public. This could coincide with a notable AI topic in the news or a local festival to attract attention. Demonstrations (like AI-generated art galleries or live AI music) at the opening can showcase the fun side of GenAI. - **Regular Schedule Establishment:** Publish a public schedule for at least one month out, including a consistent routine (e.g., *Mon/Wed drop-in hours, Tues/Thurs workshops, Sat special event*). Consistency helps people form habits around visiting. Use this period to test different time slots and see when attendance is highest (e.g., are evenings or weekends more popular? Do we get midday drop-ins from shoppers on the high street?). - **Marketing & Outreach:** Intensify marketing – local newspaper article, a segment on community radio, flyers in shops, talks at schools or Rotary clubs – to announce the hub. Emphasize *real stories* from early users: for instance, if a few local residents in the first month learned something cool (say a retiree who used AI to write a poem for their grandchild, or a student who coded their first AI app), get testimonials (with permission) and include those in promotions. Nothing draws people more than relatable success stories showing “people like me” can do this. - **Gather Feedback Continuously:** After each event or interaction, encourage feedback. This can be informal chats or a quick feedback form. Identify pain points (e.g., “the workshop was too short”, “I felt lost at first”, or “I wish you had a session on X topic”) and rapidly adjust. The small size of pilot operations is an advantage – we can pivot quickly without bureaucracy. For example, if we learn that many local shop owners are curious but only free after 7pm, we might add an evening seminar tailored to them. Or if teenagers start coming in groups, maybe set a specific teen-focused afternoon to better accommodate them. - **Community Building:** By the end of Phase 2, aim to seed an initial *community of practice*. This could be a mailing list or WhatsApp/Discord group where attendees can stay connected. Facilitating community interaction outside of physical meetups will deepen engagement. We'll also identify enthusiastic participants who could become volunteer helpers or “champions” for the hub. If someone keeps coming back, we might invite them to lead a mini-session on something they learned – giving them ownership.

Milestone: By Month 6, the pilot should have served a significant number of unique individuals (goal might be ~50-100 people through the door) and run several successful events. We should have concrete data on what works and a growing list of community members interested in continuing. A formal **review at 6 months** will be done, analyzing feedback and outcomes to decide on adjustments. Ideally, by now we also have visibility into a sustainable *business model* (next phase) – e.g., are people willing to pay small fees for certain workshops? Is the café revenue covering costs? What sponsor interest has materialized? These insights will shape Phase 3.

Phase 3: Refinement and Growth (Months 7–12) – Solidifying the Model

- **Enhance Offerings:** Expand or refine the program lineup based on pilot feedback. Introduce new courses or drop programs that had low interest. This phase might see more specialized workshops as our team's capacity grows (e.g., bringing in guest instructors for niche topics like AI in healthcare, if there's local interest from a nearby hospital or medical college). We will also polish the content and pedagogy: creating better handouts, improving tutorial code based on where people got stuck, etc. Continuous improvement will raise the quality and reputation of the hub's learning experience. - **Infrastructure Upgrade:** With proof of concept in hand, we can justify investing in better equipment or space enhancements. Perhaps we add a few more powerful PCs (for tasks like image generation which

need good GPUs) or even a small local server to host open-source models that many can access simultaneously. If the pilot was in a very small/shared space, we might move to a slightly larger permanent venue on the high street as resources allow. The **ambience** can be enhanced too – more furniture, decor showcasing AI art from participants, etc., to make the hub feel vibrant and unique. - **Diversify Funding Streams:** In Phase 3, a major focus is ensuring financial sustainability. By now we will pursue: - **Sponsorships and Grants:** Armed with pilot success stories and metrics, approach larger sponsors (tech firms, innovation grants, government digital inclusion funds). For example, an EU digital skills grant or a corporate social responsibility (CSR) donation from a company like Google or Microsoft could be targeted. We'll keep sponsorship **independent and transparent** – e.g., a company could sponsor new equipment or a series of workshops, but they don't control the content (similar to how a library might accept sponsored computers). - **Revenue Opportunities:** Experiment with modest revenue models that align with the mission. This could include “*pay-what-you-can*” contributions for workshops (while keeping basic access free), premium advanced courses for a fee (targeted at professionals, with proceeds funding the free community programs), or simply increasing the café's offerings. Another idea is offering **consulting services or private training**: for instance, if a local business wants a dedicated training for their staff on using AI, the hub team could provide that for a fee. This leverages our expertise to earn income in a way that doesn't exploit the community base – in fact, it spreads AI knowledge further into local businesses and brings revenue that subsidizes community operations. We will also explore merchandise (like T-shirts with AI-inspired art designed by community members) or maker shop items, but these are secondary. - **Membership Model Consideration:** We might introduce an optional membership or patron program. For example, community members can subscribe a small monthly amount as “Friends of the GenAI Hub” to support the cause, in return for perks like early registration to events or a free coffee. Many makerspaces and community workshops use membership as a support mechanism ¹² (keeping in mind not to gate core services behind a paywall, but to give an avenue for those willing to contribute). - **Metrics and Evaluation:** Define KPIs to measure success: number of active participants, demographic spread (are we reaching seniors, youth, etc. as intended?), skill improvements (perhaps measured by pre/post surveys in courses), number of projects created by members, and community satisfaction ratings. By month 12 we should produce an evaluation report. This report will not only guide our own improvement but also serve as a **marketing tool** for Phase 4 (showing impact to potential partners in other locations).

Milestone: At one year mark, the hub should ideally transition from “pilot” to a more permanent institution in the town. We expect to have a stable schedule of well-attended programs, a balanced budget (or clear path to one with confirmed funding sources), and documented impact. A one-year **community showcase event** can be held to celebrate — inviting the public to see what participants have created or learned (like an “AI Project Fair” exhibition of works, or a demo day). By now, local word-of-mouth should be strong, with the hub recognized as part of the town's fabric. This sets the stage for expanding the concept.

Phase 4: Scale Out (Year 2 and beyond) – Replication and Networking

- **Refine the Playbook:** Using the experience from the pilot town (e.g., London high street location or a town in Portugal as initial examples), create a **replication playbook**. This would include documented best practices, checklists for setting up a GenAI community space, curriculum outlines, and case studies of what worked. Because all our materials are open source and Creative Commons, we can freely share this playbook with anyone interested. - **New Locations Pilot:** Identify one or two new communities to establish the hub model. These could be in different cities (perhaps one in another London neighborhood, one in a Portuguese town to test in a different national context, as the founder has ties to Portugal) or elsewhere in Europe. We would not rush to open many branches immediately, but rather **pilot the transferability** of the model. For each new location, we might partner with a local organization to run it (for instance, a local library or a community college might host the hub using our

framework). The original team can act as advisors/trainers to the new locations, helping them avoid pitfalls. - **Network of Hubs:** As more hubs come online, form a network for collaboration and knowledge-sharing between them. This could evolve into something like an “**Open GenAI Hub Network**” where each location adapts to its community but shares resources globally. Joint events could even be organized (imagine a multi-city AI hackathon where teams from different hubs collaborate or compete). The network could collectively approach larger sponsors (e.g., an EU-wide grant for digital innovation) since the impact is broader. - **Long-term Sustainability:** Each hub, being a CIC or equivalent locally, would sustain itself with local revenue/support, but the network can pool certain resources (like development of new training materials or bulk purchase of equipment). We will also keep updating the tech stack – as GenAI technology evolves (new models, better hardware requirements), the network can help each other stay cutting-edge. By staying open-source and community-driven, we ensure adaptability and avoid dependency on any single tech provider’s whims.

Milestone: In 2-3 years, success would be seeing multiple towns with vibrant GenAI third spaces, all inspired by the original, each self-sufficient yet connected. We would measure large-scale impact (hundreds or thousands of people trained, career pivots enabled, projects born, etc.). Ultimately, we hope the concept influences even existing institutions – for example, public libraries might adopt some of our programming, or governments might allocate funds for such community tech centers seeing the positive outcomes. The **end goal** is a future where walking into a “*GenAI hub*” to learn tech is as normal as walking into a library or a coffee shop – an accepted part of the social infrastructure of towns, promoting lifelong learning and innovation.

Governance and Operations

Organizational Structure: The hub will operate as a **Community Interest Company (CIC)** (in the UK context) or a similar not-for-profit social enterprise structure in other countries. A CIC is specifically intended for businesses serving a social purpose or community benefit ¹⁰. This means while the hub can engage in trading activities (like selling coffee or tickets for advanced workshops), it is legally bound to reinvest profits into the community mission. An asset lock prevents any sale of the company or distribution of profits to private individuals ¹¹, ensuring the space can never “sell out” its community ethos. We will establish a board of directors for oversight, including representatives from various stakeholder groups (educators, tech industry, local community, possibly even youth representation). Regular meetings will review finances, impact metrics, and ethical considerations (for instance, ensuring the AI tools and content provided are used responsibly and align with community values).

Staffing and Volunteers: Initially, much of the effort will be volunteer-driven (including by the founder, Dinis Cruz, and peers passionate about the idea). As we stabilize, we might hire a **Hub Coordinator** – someone to manage day-to-day operations (opening/closing, scheduling events, maintaining equipment, training volunteers). Other roles may be part-time or volunteer-based, such as: - AI Mentors (volunteers with tech know-how who help users one-on-one), - Instructors (paid a stipend per workshop or volunteering their time to teach their specialty), - Barista/Admin (if the café element is significant, a person to handle the coffee bar and greet visitors).

Keeping staff lean is important for financial sustainability, but we also don’t want volunteer burnout. The CIC structure allows us to pay staff reasonable wages as needed, and as funding improves we can increase staffing for reliability.

Community Involvement: We will encourage a sense of *community ownership*. For example, forming a **User Council** or feedback group that any regular participant can join to voice ideas and help shape programming. The more the local community feels it is “their space,” the more resilient the hub will be.

We might implement a membership voting system on certain decisions (taking inspiration from cooperative models). For instance, if expanding hours or buying new equipment, we poll the community members on preferences. This inclusive governance will keep the hub aligned with actual user needs and maintain trust.

Operational Policies: A few key policies will guide daily operation:

- **Open Access Ethos:** The space is open to all regardless of background. We will have a simple code of conduct to ensure it remains welcoming – e.g., zero tolerance for harassment, respect others' learning journeys, etc. This will be visibly posted.
- **Safe and Ethical AI Use:** Since GenAI can sometimes produce problematic content, we will implement usage guidelines. For instance, when using image generators or chatbots in the hub, we encourage ethical prompts and have filters in place to block obviously inappropriate requests (much like library internet filters). Mentors will guide discussions on AI ethics as part of learning ("just because the AI can say something doesn't mean it should"). We want users to leave with not just skills but a responsible mindset about AI.
- **Equipment Use:** Devices can be freely used on-site, but in general not taken off-site (unless we develop a lending program for small devices like Raspberry Pis for home projects). We will use booking systems for popular equipment if needed (e.g., a PC with a high-end GPU might have a sign-up sheet for 1-hour slots if demand is high).
- **Content and IP:** Everything created in the educational context (workshop slides, demo code, etc.) will be open-source/CC. For individuals' personal projects, they of course retain their own IP – but we will encourage open sharing. If someone builds a great prompt or a cool script at the hub, we might ask to feature it in our public repo (with credit) so others can learn. This builds a **knowledge commons** around the hub.
- **Hours of Operation:** Likely open at least 5 days a week, with a mix of daytime and evening hours to cater to different groups. Specific hours will evolve based on usage patterns found in Phase 2. We may start with e.g. afternoons into early evenings on weekdays plus a Saturday morning/afternoon. As volunteer capacity grows, expand hours. We will clearly communicate the schedule on our website and on the storefront.
- **Health and Safety:** Ensure the space complies with all regulations (fire safety, accessibility for those with disabilities, etc.). Particularly, provide a safe environment for young participants – following safeguarding guidelines if running youth programs (e.g., background checks for mentors working with minors, requiring that children under a certain age are accompanied by an adult, etc., similar to Code Club's safeguarding policies).

Overall, the **operations** will strive to be professional enough to ensure reliability and safety, yet informal enough to keep a community-driven charm. We want people to feel they can just pop in and tinker, as comfortable as they would be in a friend's living room, yet also trust that the organization behind it is solid and enduring.

Financial Plan and Sustainability

Establishing a sustainable financial model is crucial. The aim is to combine **community support, earned income, and sponsorship** in a balanced way, so that the hub can cover its costs while keeping the barrier to entry low. Key elements of the financial plan include:

- **Initial Funding:** We anticipate needing seed funding for startup costs (equipment purchase, initial rent, etc.). This might come from innovation grants, a crowdfunding campaign, or angel donors aligned with the mission. Given the open-source and community focus, we will also approach organizations like Mozilla Foundation, IEEE Humanitarian Tech, EU Digital Innovation

funds, etc., for one-time grants to get started. Startup budget will cover ~6 months of operation to give runway for the model to kick in.

- **Space and Overhead:** Ideally, a partner (city council or a sponsor) can donate or subsidize the physical space, as rent on high street property can be a major expense. If that's not possible, we'll start in smaller or shared spaces to keep overhead low. A community space that's underutilized (e.g., a library meeting room in off hours, or a closed retail store awaiting development) could be negotiated at low cost in exchange for the social benefit we provide (there is precedent of local governments supporting makerspaces or community centers in this way). Utilities and internet costs we will budget for, possibly getting a local ISP to sponsor high-speed internet in exchange for publicity.
- **Equipment and Software:** Much of our software stack is open-source (hence free), and we'll use existing computers or affordable hardware (Raspberry Pis, etc.) where possible. Still, for certain high-end needs (like powerful GPUs for AI), we might seek specific sponsorship – e.g., NVIDIA or another company might donate a couple of GPUs or edge AI devices. Maintenance costs (upgrades, repairs) will be factored into the budget from ongoing funds. We'll also explore donations of used but capable equipment from corporations upgrading their PCs.
- **Revenue Streams:** After the initial free pilot phase, we'll implement gentle revenue streams to support ongoing costs:
- **Café Sales:** The coffee/tea/snacks bar, if well-managed, can generate a modest profit. We will price items affordably but with a small margin. This has the dual benefit of keeping people in the space longer (they don't have to leave for refreshments) and bringing in funds. A real-world example: some community bookshops or arts centers survive largely due to their café revenue supporting the cultural mission. We will monitor if the café could cover a significant chunk of rent/staff.
- **Workshops/Courses:** Basic drop-in access and introductory sessions remain free, but for advanced or multi-week courses targeting professionals or advanced hobbyists, we may charge a fee (with waivers or scholarships available to ensure no one is excluded for cost). Corporate attendees especially could be charged (for instance, a local company sending employees to an "AI for managers" course could pay a training fee per head). All income from this goes back into running the hub.
- **Donations and Membership:** We will have a visible donation box and online donation link for those who want to contribute. As mentioned, a "Friends of the Hub" membership at perhaps £5-£10/month could be offered with small perks (free mug, priority event invites). Many patrons of libraries or museums are willing to donate when they see the value provided.
- **Services:** Offering services such as consulting to local businesses (as described in Phase 3) or even AI development services (some hubs spin out a small consulting wing where experienced volunteers take on projects) can generate income. This must be carefully managed to not distract from the core mission, but for example, if a local nonprofit needs help building a chatbot, our hub could do it as a paid project, thus funding our free community activities.
- **Events:** Hackathons or competitions might have sponsorship or ticketing that brings in some money. An annual conference or fair on community AI could be monetized lightly (sell booths to sponsors, small ticket price for attendees, etc.). These are supplementary ideas as the community grows.
- **Expenses and Cost Control:** Major expenses will be rent, utilities, equipment purchase/maintenance, and any salaries for coordinators. We'll seek to minimize rent (via partnerships)

and keep staffing efficient. Volunteer contribution is a huge cost saver – the more volunteer hours we get for teaching and mentoring, the less payroll is needed. However, we will budget to **compensate key roles** that are hard to fill purely with volunteers (like a full-time coordinator or cleaning/maintenance tasks) because relying entirely on unpaid labor can be unsustainable long-term.

- Other expenses include consumables (coffee, paper, cleaning supplies), which are hopefully offset by café income. We'll implement good budgeting practices and transparency – since as a CIC we may publish annual reports, community members can see how funds are used, further building trust.
- **Break-even and Growth:** We will forecast the break-even point (e.g., X number of paying course participants or Y amount of monthly sponsor contributions). The goal is not profit, but we do need to cover costs to be viable. Once we reach a stable financial footing in one location, surplus funds can be reinvested into expanding programs or saved as reserve. If we expand to multiple sites, each should aim to sustain itself, though there might be a central fund for shared development (possibly funded by external grants for the broader initiative).

The **business model validation** will be an ongoing process. If certain revenue ideas don't work (say membership uptake is low), we'll try others (maybe merchandising or rentals). Given our iterate-fast philosophy, we'll treat the financial model as a product to refine. The key is staying true to the mission: revenue generation should never undermine openness or inclusivity. For example, we wouldn't suddenly charge for basic access because that would deter the very people we aim to help. Instead, we'll creatively monetize around the edges in a way that *adds value* (advanced content, convenience, B2B services) without eroding the free core offerings.

One promising sign for our model is that similar community tech spaces have found ways to persist. Recall the earlier example of ARTEC in Pottstown: it is run as part of a social innovation lab with partnerships and presumably some school backing, and it offers free adult workshops with limited seats ¹³ – indicating grants or sponsors likely cover the cost so they can be free to the public. Likewise, many makerspaces operate on memberships or mixed funding and have survived by being community hubs. We will learn from those precedents (what worked, what pitfalls). Ultimately, by diversifying funding sources and keeping expenses lean initially, we improve our resilience.

Anticipated Outcomes and Impact

If executed well, the High Street GenAI Learning Hub can yield significant positive outcomes for individuals, the local community, and society at large. Below are the key anticipated impacts:

- **Increased AI Literacy and Skills:** Hundreds of community members will gain firsthand experience with generative AI. Instead of fearing the unknown, they will understand AI's capabilities and limitations. We expect participants to come away with concrete new skills – for some, that might be learning to query ChatGPT effectively for research or work tasks; for others, it could be the ability to fine-tune a simple AI model or create digital art. These skills can enhance employability (e.g., someone adding "AI-assisted data analysis" to their resume) and everyday efficiency (using AI tools to solve personal tasks). In line with broader efforts (like government programs to boost digital skills), our hub could help raise the overall digital competency of the town's population. Success stories might include career changes – e.g., a mid-career professional who, through our courses, gains enough AI knowledge to transition into a new role in tech or improve their business processes. We will track such stories as ultimate proof of concept.

- **Community Empowerment and Inclusion:** The hub will serve as a **community equalizer**. People who lack resources at home (no computer or no fast internet) will have a place to access cutting-edge technology for free. This helps bridge the digital divide. Importantly, by focusing on *inclusive design* (welcoming all ages, offering beginner sessions), we anticipate greater tech confidence among groups often left behind. For example, seniors who regularly attend may no longer feel intimidated by online services or AI-driven tools and can better connect with a digital world (reducing isolation). Likewise, young people from families that can't afford the latest gadgets will get exposure to these tools, perhaps sparking interest in STEM fields. By **bridging generations and backgrounds**, the hub strengthens social cohesion: it's a positive community space where a diverse mix of people interact regularly, improving understanding across social lines.
- **Local Innovation and Economic Growth:** With social entrepreneurs and small business owners in the mix, we expect the hub to act as a **mini incubator** for innovation. New project ideas will germinate; some may turn into startups or community projects that create jobs or solve local problems. Even existing small businesses could see growth from adopting AI (a shop owner who learns to automate their inventory management or marketing could increase efficiency and sales). The town could develop a reputation as a forward-looking "AI-friendly" community, attracting talent or investment. In a broader sense, keeping the high street relevant is a goal – by drawing foot traffic for learning, the hub can indirectly benefit neighboring shops and the high street economy. (It's similar to how a popular library or museum brings people to an area; here, people might come for an AI class and then patronize a nearby restaurant or bookstore.) In policy terms, this aligns with revitalizing high streets by making them centers of experience and education, not just retail.
- **Cultural and Creative Enrichment:** Generative AI is as much an artistic tool as a technical one. We foresee a blossoming of local creativity as people experiment. The hub might catalyze community art projects (e.g., a mural designed with AI assistance, local history stories generated and published as a zine, etc.). Cultural institutions like art galleries or theaters could collaborate with the hub to produce novel exhibits or performances involving AI. By demystifying AI, we also help incorporate it into the fabric of local culture in a thoughtful way. Rather than AI being seen as a threatening external force, it becomes a *community instrument* – like paint or clay – for expression and problem-solving. This could influence the narrative and acceptance of AI in society: showing that AI can be *collaborative and human-centered*, not just a corporate or government domain.
- **Model for Other Communities:** Documenting and sharing the journey means that our successes and lessons can be replicated. If our hub flourishes, it provides a **template for any town** to create their own safe space for GenAI exploration. This could potentially scale impact far beyond our locality. An indicator of success would be inquiries or visits from other towns wanting to learn how to do it, or perhaps pilot hubs starting in other cities with our guidance (as planned in Phase 4). The formation of a network of GenAI hubs could accelerate **grassroots AI education** globally. In essence, we could help seed a movement of community-driven AI learning, complementing formal education and online resources. The *open-source ethos* magnifies this impact – everything we produce (curriculum, best practices) being freely available lowers the barrier for others to emulate the concept.
- **Positive Shift in AI Perception:** On a qualitative level, one of the biggest impacts might be how people feel about AI. By having a local, human-facilitated place to explore AI, fear and mystery are reduced. Instead of seeing AI as a black box or a job-stealing boogeyman, residents will more likely see it as a toolkit they can pick up and use. This more informed and nuanced public

understanding can lead to better discourse about AI in the community (e.g., around ethics, privacy, and policy). When people *understand* a technology, they can engage in shaping its use. So indirectly, the hub could lead to a community that demands and co-creates **ethical, community-oriented AI applications**. For example, citizens might collaborate with the local council on AI solutions for public services, because now they have the know-how to contribute. The empowerment aspect is not just individual productivity but collective agency over the technology in our lives.

In summary, the project's success will be measured not just in numbers of participants, but in stories of transformation: the retiree who finds new purpose writing AI-augmented poetry, the teenager who discovers a career path, the shopkeeper who saved her business by adopting AI, or simply the fact that on any given afternoon, one can peek into the hub and see a 70-year-old and a 17-year-old laughing and learning together over a laptop. Those are the snapshots of impact we strive for. By revitalizing the concept of a community "third space" for the digital age, we uphold the principle that technology should be empowering and inclusive. As one design study on libraries noted, libraries (and by extension community tech hubs) cater to all walks of life and remain relevant through all shifts in politics, economics, and technology ¹⁴. Our GenAI Hub will carry that torch forward, ensuring generative AI becomes a tool for **collective growth and creativity** on every high street that embraces the idea.

Conclusion and Next Steps

We propose to start this journey in 2025 with a pilot in a specific community (for example, a London neighborhood high street or a town in Portugal), and then refine and expand. This project plan has outlined how we will create the space, engage the community, sustain the operation, and evaluate the outcomes. The concept is ambitious yet grounded in proven models (libraries, makerspaces, code clubs) and fueled by the timely opportunity presented by generative AI's rise.

The **next immediate steps** are to secure initial supporters and resources (space, funding, volunteers) and to begin the pilot implementation as described in Phase 1. Once those building blocks are in place, the GenAI Learning Hub can open its doors and start making a difference one curious visitor at a time.

In closing, this initiative represents a fusion of **innovation with community spirit**. It's about planting a seed on the high street that can grow into a hub of knowledge, much like the public libraries or civic centers of old, but focused on the tools of the future. By starting small and remaining adaptable, we increase our chances of creating something truly sustainable and impactful. The project's alignment with open-source principles and community values gives it a distinctive strength: it is not owned by any corporation or limited to any elite—it's by the people, for the people, *powered by* people (and their AI partners).

With careful execution, the High Street GenAI Hub will demonstrate that empowering people with AI is not only possible but transformative at a grassroots level. We look forward to reporting on the successes and lessons of the pilot, and to seeing this idea spread to many other communities in the coming years. **Let's bring GenAI to Main Street, and make learning and innovating an everyday social experience.**

Looking ahead, we invite collaborators, sponsors, and enthusiasts to join us in this endeavor. Together, we can ensure that generative AI's benefits are accessible to all – turning potential anxiety into excitement and passive consumers into active co-creators of our shared technological future. The third space for AI on the high street awaits, and its doors will be open to everyone.

Sources:

- Zadie Smith on libraries as non-commercial high street spaces ¹
- European Parliament study noting libraries as a “third space” anchoring the high street ²
- Singapore’s initiative to upskill 40+ aged citizens in AI (continuous learning for all ages) ⁴ ⁵
- Raspberry Pi Foundation’s Code Club model – free coding clubs with projects in Scratch/Python, demonstrating volunteer-driven tech education ⁶
- Example of a community makerspace integrated on a town’s High Street (Pottstown Social Innovations Lab with ARTEC makerspace and café) ⁷ ⁸
- Open-source AI model ethos (community reuse and improvement of AI models without proprietary lock-in) ³
- UK Community Interest Company (CIC) defined – a social enterprise business structure for community benefit, ensuring mission lock ¹⁰ ¹¹

¹ ¹⁴ Library as Third Space — Moriel Design

<https://www.moriel.design.com/library-as-third-space>

² [PDF] PUBLIC LIBRARIES – THEIR NEW ROLE - European Parliament

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⁶ ⁹ Learn | Coding for kids and teens | Raspberry Pi Foundation – Raspberry Pi

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⁷ ARTEC Pottstown Community Makerspace - Hobart's Run

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⁸ ¹³ New Workshops Planned at Pottstown Innovations Lab

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¹⁰ ¹¹ Community interest company - Wikipedia

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¹² Does anyone actually pay to be a member of a makerspace? : r/maker

https://www.reddit.com/r/maker/comments/5mhcj1/does_anyone_actually_pay_to_be_a_member_of_a/